

Korean for Beginners — 50 Essential Phrases to Know Before You Go

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You don't need to be fluent to get around Korea. Even knowing a handful of phrases will earn you smiles, better service, and a much richer travel experience. Here are the 50 most useful Korean phrases — with simple pronunciation guides.

Pronunciation tip: In romanization below, "eo" sounds like the "u" in "but", "eu" sounds like the "i" in "sir", and "ae" sounds like "eh". Most sounds are close to English — just say it confidently!

Greetings & Basic Courtesy

KOREAN	ROMANIZATION	MEANING
안녕하세요 <i>Annyeonghaseyo</i>		Hello (formal, standard)
안녕 <i>Annyeong</i>		Hi / Bye (informal, friends)
감사합니다 <i>Gamsahamnida</i>		Thank you (formal)
고마워요 <i>Gomawoyo</i>		Thank you (casual)
죄송합니다 <i>Joesonghamnida</i>		I'm sorry (formal)

괜찮아요 <i>Gwaenchanayo</i>	It's okay / No problem
네 <i>Ne</i>	Yes
아니요 <i>Aniyo</i>	No
잠깐만요 <i>Jamkkanmanyoy</i>	One moment please
모르겠어요 <i>Moreugeseoyo</i>	I don't know

Ordering Food & At Restaurants

KOREAN	ROMANIZATION	MEANING
이거 주세요 <i>Igeo juseyo</i>		This one, please (point at menu)
얼마예요? <i>Eolmayeyo?</i>		How much is it?
맛있어요! <i>Massisseoyo!</i>		It's delicious!
물 주세요 <i>Mul juseyo</i>		Water, please
계산해 주세요 <i>Gyesan-hae juseyo</i>		The bill, please
하나 더 주세요 <i>Hana deo juseyo</i>		One more, please
맵지 않게 해주세요 <i>Maepji ange haejuseyo</i>		Not spicy, please
포장해 주세요 <i>Pojang-hae juseyo</i>		To go, please
저기요! <i>Jeogiyo!</i>		Excuse me! (calling a server)

카드 돼요?

Kadeu dwaeyo?

Do you take card?

Shopping

KOREAN	ROMANIZATION	MEANING
이거 있어요? <i>Igeo isseoyo?</i>		Do you have this?
더 싸게 해주세요 <i>Deo ssage haejuseyo</i>		Can you give me a discount?
이거 얼마예요? <i>Igeo eolmayeyo?</i>		How much is this?
너무 비싸요 <i>Neomu bissayo</i>		Too expensive
그냥 볼게요 <i>Geunyang bolgeyo</i>		Just looking (politely declining help)
다른 색 있어요? <i>Dareun saek isseoyo?</i>		Do you have other colors?

Getting Around

KOREAN	ROMANIZATION	MEANING
어디에 있어요? <i>Eodie isseoyo?</i>		Where is it?
지하철역이 어디에 있어요? <i>Jihacheol-yeogi eodie isseoyo?</i>		Where is the subway station?
여기로 가주세요 <i>Yeogiro gajuseyo</i>		Take me here please (show map to driver)
왼쪽 <i>Oenjjok</i>		Left
오른쪽 <i>Oreunjjok</i>		Right

직진 <i>Jikjin</i>	Straight ahead
화장실이 어디에 있어요? <i>Hwajangsili eodie isseoyo?</i>	Where is the bathroom?
공항에 가주세요 <i>Gonghange gajuseyo</i>	To the airport, please

Emergencies & Getting Help

KOREAN	ROMANIZATION	MEANING
도와주세요! <i>Dowajuseyo!</i>		Help me!
병원이 어디에 있어요? <i>Byeongwoni eodie isseoyo?</i>		Where is the hospital?
영어 할 수 있어요? <i>Yeongeo hal su isseoyo?</i>		Can you speak English?
경찰을 불러주세요 <i>Gyeongchareul bulleojuseyo</i>		Please call the police
아파요 <i>Apayo</i>		I'm sick / It hurts
길을 잃었어요 <i>Gireul ireoesseoyo</i>		I'm lost

Useful Everyday Phrases

KOREAN	ROMANIZATION	MEANING
한국어 조금 해요 <i>Hangugeo jogeum haeyo</i>		I speak a little Korean
천천히 말해주세요 <i>Cheoncheonhi malhaejuseyo</i>		Please speak slowly
다시 말해주세요 <i>Dasi malhaejuseyo</i>		Please say that again

이름이 뭐예요? <i>Ireumi mwoyeyo?</i>	What's your name?
제 이름은 __이에요 <i>Je ireumeun __ ieoyo</i>	My name is __
반가워요 <i>Bangawoyo</i>	Nice to meet you
안녕히 계세요 <i>Annyeonghi gyeseyo</i>	Goodbye (said to person staying)
안녕히 가세요 <i>Annyeonghi gaseyo</i>	Goodbye (said to person leaving)

Practice tip: Download the **Papago** app (by Naver) — it has excellent Korean-English translation and even real-time camera translation for signs and menus. Use it alongside these phrases!

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